SafeTrade

Proposed Secure Transaction Layer for Facebook Marketplace

Validation Findings & Decision

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Confidential. Intended for internal review.

Contents

1 Executive Summary **2**

2 Background **2**

2.1 The Original Proposal 2

2.2 Assumptions Under Test 2

2.3 Success Criteria and Decision Framework 3

3 Validation Activities **3**

3.1 Survey Prototype 3

3.2 Data Collection 3

3.3 Data Processing 4

3.4 Who Responded 4

4 Findings **5**

4.1 Safety Concerns Affect How Users Trade 5

4.2 Fraud and Misrepresentation Are Leading Concerns 6

4.3 Interest in Escrow Does Not Establish Trust 6

4.4 Users Say They Would Pay, but the Economics Remain Open 7

4.5 Early-Access Sign-ups Provide a Limited Signal 8

5 Evaluation Against Success Criteria **8**

6 Limitations of the Evidence **9**

7 Decision **9**

7.1 Outcome Under the Framework 9

7.2 Decision Taken 9

7.3 Rationale 10

7.4 Conditions for Revisiting 10

8 What Was Retained and Learned **11**

8.1 Retained Work 11

8.2 Lessons 11

9 Next Steps **11**

A Data Pipeline **13**

1 Executive Summary

I proposed SafeTrade to address a practical problem: a buyer and seller can agree on a Facebook Marketplace deal, but neither has much assurance that the other person will follow through. The April 2026 validation plan proposed an escrow service and required evidence before committing to product development.

Between 13 and 21 April 2026, I shared a story-led survey prototype through personal and student networks. It received 59 submissions. After removing one duplicate, 58 responses were analysed, including 26 from people who use Facebook Marketplace.

The responses suggest that safety is a meaningful concern within this group. Half of the Marketplace users reported being scammed or nearly scammed, and 64% reported cancelling a deal because they felt unsafe. Escrow was the most frequently requested safety feature across respondents, and 92% of Marketplace users said they would pay a fee. On the measures used in this evaluation, two of the three original success criteria were met; the third was not tested.

These findings do not yet make a strong case for building SafeTrade. The target sample was small, and respondents saw the proposed solution before answering. The most common fee selected by users was R5–R10, but the cost of delivering the service was not established. Most importantly, the survey did not directly test whether people would trust a new platform with their money or use it during an actual deal.

My decision is to pause SafeTrade. The evidence falls under *Refine* in the original framework, but I am not committing to another validation phase at this stage. No MVP will be built for now. The prototype, anonymised data and pipeline have been retained, and Section 7 explains what would need to change before I reconsider the project.

2 Background

2.1 The Original Proposal

SafeTrade was proposed as a third-party service for buyers and sellers who have already agreed on a Marketplace transaction. The buyer would pay the platform, the seller would receive confirmation that funds were held, and the money would be released after the buyer confirmed receipt of the item.

The intention was to reduce payment fraud and give both parties more confidence in completing a deal. Product misrepresentation and unsafe meetups were also part of the original problem, although holding funds alone would not resolve either of them fully.

2.2 Assumptions Under Test

The original proposal identified four assumptions that needed to hold before development could be justified. Table 1 sets out how they were approached in this validation.

Table 1: Foundational assumptions and validation coverage.

ID	Assumption	Question to answer	Coverage
H1	Perceived value of safety	Do users experience safety concerns that affect how they trade?	Survey Q4–Q8
H2	Willingness to pay	Would users pay a fee for additional protection?	Survey Q10–Q11
H3	Trust in the platform	Would users trust a new third party to hold their money?	Q9 and Q11 provide indirect signals only
H4	Workflow adoption	Would users add SafeTrade to the way they complete a deal?	Demand test not run

2.3 Success Criteria and Decision Framework

The proposal identified three success criteria: a majority concerned about transaction safety, a meaningful portion willing to pay, and observable interest in a simulated "Pay Securely" option. It also defined the following decision framework.

Table 2: Decision framework from the original proposal.

Outcome	Action
Proceed	Criteria are met. Move forward with an MVP.
Refine	Results are mixed. Refine the problem, value proposition or target segment.
Reassess	Core assumptions are not supported. Re-evaluate the approach.

3 Validation Activities

3.1 Survey Prototype

I used a mobile web prototype rather than a plain form so respondents could picture the transaction. The opening story followed a student buying a laptop and a working professional selling it. The buyer feared losing money; the seller feared a fake proof of payment. The story then showed how SafeTrade was intended to help both of them.

This made the idea easier to explain, but it also affected the quality of the test. Respondents were introduced to both the risk and my proposed answer before I asked for their views. Their responses therefore reflect an introduction to the concept, rather than an independent measure of the problem or demand.

The survey contained twelve questions covering respondent profiles, safety experiences, the severity of the problem, proposed features, payment preferences and optional feedback. Respondents could also leave a name and phone number for early access, or submit without contact details.

3.2 Data Collection

The prototype was hosted online and shared through personal and student networks. Answers were recorded in a private Google Sheet. From 13 to 21 April 2026, 59 submissions were

received.

3.3 Data Processing

The first analysis used a single notebook. After reviewing it, I replaced it with a tested extract–load–transform (ELT) pipeline. Personal fields are removed at ingestion; the remaining answers are retained as recorded, then cleaned and summarised in separate stages. Eleven data quality checks are used before results are published.

The pipeline described in Appendix A provides a reproducible route from the anonymised responses to the report's figures. It also exposed errors that needed to be corrected before I could rely on the analysis.

Table 3: Processing issues and corrective actions.

Issue	Effect	Action taken
Names and phone numbers entered a public code repository.	Respondents' personal information was exposed.	The repository was rebuilt without those fields or their history. Personal fields are now removed at ingestion.
Three answer types were missed in the first notebook.	Thirteen scam-experience responses were omitted from the results.	Answer mappings were corrected; unrecognised answers now stop the pipeline.
R10–R20 was mapped to R5–R10.	Five fee preferences were misreported.	Fee bands are matched exactly.
Identical answers arrived fourteen seconds apart.	One submission was counted twice.	Identical answers submitted within two minutes are treated as duplicates.
Percentages used inconsistent bases.	Some results were not comparable.	Each percentage uses those who answered the question, with its base recorded.

Removing information from the repository does not establish that every copy of the exposed data has disappeared. The pipeline change prevents those fields from entering future analysis outputs; it should not be treated as evidence that the earlier exposure has been fully resolved.

3.4 Who Responded

Only 26 of the 58 respondents reported using Facebook Marketplace. The remaining 32 said they never use it. The sample was also concentrated among people aged 18–24, with no respondents aged 35 or older.

Table 4: Profile of the 58 responses analysed.

Group	Responses	Share
Use Marketplace daily, weekly or occasionally	26	45%
Never use Marketplace	32	55%
Aged 18–24	52	90%
Aged 25–34	6	10%

Where available, I use Marketplace-user results to assess the original assumptions. Some feature and concern figures use all respondents; these are identified explicitly and should not be read as estimates for Marketplace users alone. Percentages are rounded, and question-level bases can be smaller than the group totals because some respondents skipped questions.

4 Findings

4.1 Safety Concerns Affect How Users Trade

Half of Marketplace users reported being scammed or nearly scammed, compared with 13% of non-users. Among those answering the question, 64% of users reported cancelling a deal because they felt unsafe, compared with 29% of non-users.

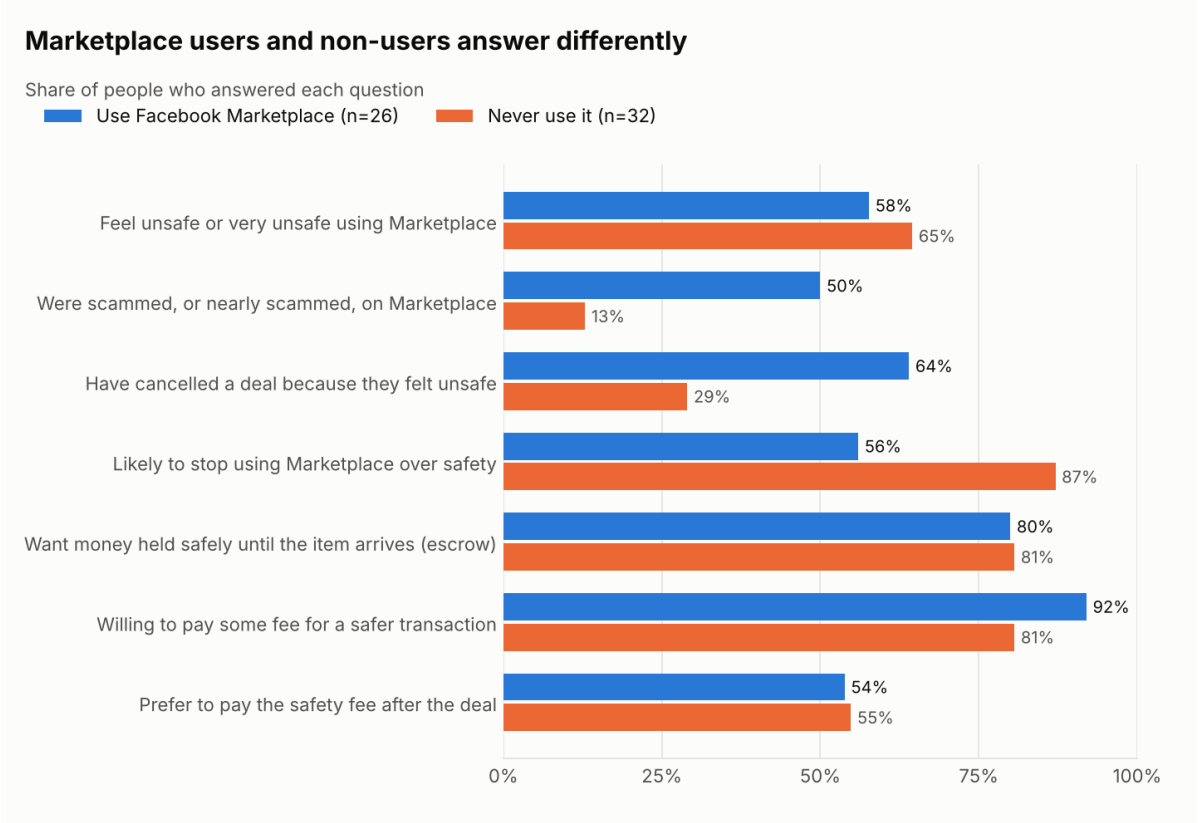


Figure 1: Marketplace users ($n = 26$) and non-users ($n = 32$). Each measure excludes skipped answers.

For me, the cancelled deals are particularly relevant: safety concerns appear to affect whether transactions go ahead. The survey did not measure financial losses or establish how representative these experiences are, so I cannot infer their wider economic cost.

Non-users reported feeling slightly less safe than users: 65% against 58%. Fear could be one reason for avoiding Marketplace, but the survey did not ask why they do not use it. Also, 87% of non-users said they were likely to stop using Marketplace. That question does not meaningfully measure withdrawal among people who already do not use the platform.

Assessment: H1 has preliminary support within this sample. Users describe safety concerns and changes in trading behaviour; the findings do not establish prevalence across South Africa.

4.2 Fraud and Misrepresentation Are Leading Concerns

Across all respondents, fake sellers and items not matching their descriptions were the leading concerns, followed by payment fraud.

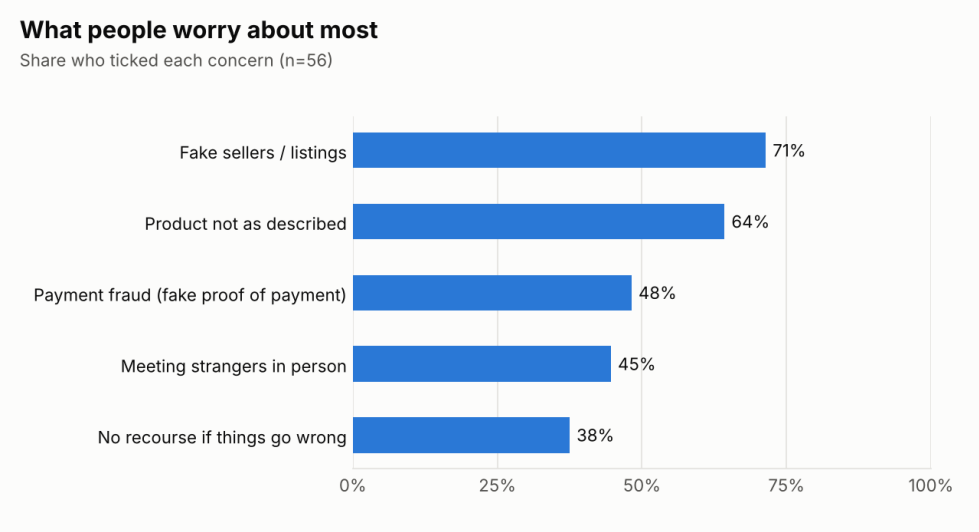


Figure 2: Concerns selected by all respondents who answered this question ($n = 56$).

Escrow could reduce some non-delivery risks if funds remain protected until the agreed release conditions are met. It would still need a way to handle disagreements about an item's condition or description. Unsafe meetups, raised by 45% of respondents, would also require measures beyond holding payment.

Assessment: the proposed service addresses part of the problem. Its value depends on the release rules, dispute process and protections around the funds, rather than simply adding an escrow step.

4.3 Interest in Escrow Does Not Establish Trust

Escrow was the most frequently selected safety feature, chosen by 80% of respondents. Ratings, safe meetup locations and verification were also popular.

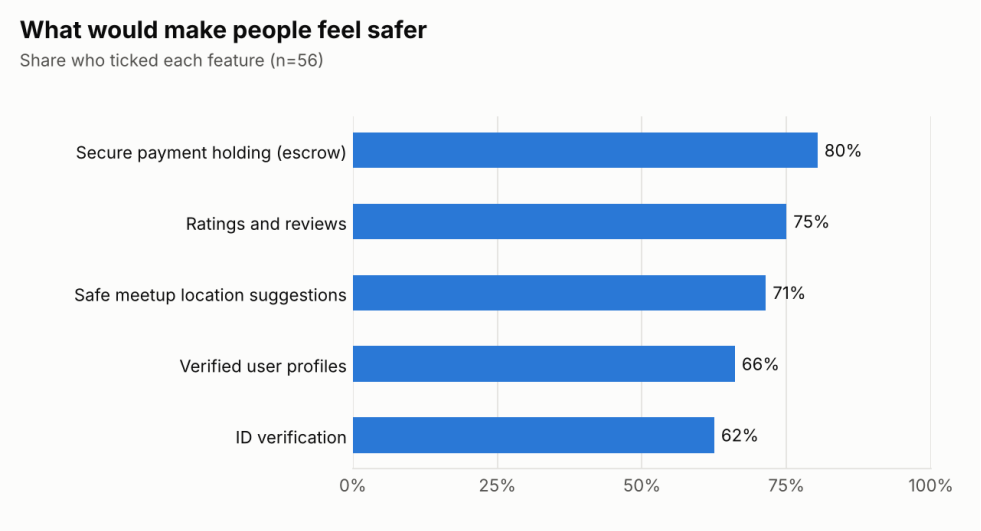


Figure 3: Safety features selected by all respondents answering this question ($n = 56$).

These responses suggest that people like the idea of payment protection. They do not tell me whether those people would send money to SafeTrade. A respondent can want escrow while still being unwilling to trust an unfamiliar provider.

The other features also deserve consideration if the project returns, although their costs and effectiveness were not evaluated in this study.

Assessment: the survey provides an indirect signal relevant to H3, but trust in a new platform remains untested.

4.4 Users Say They Would Pay, but the Economics Remain Open

Among Marketplace users, 92% said they would pay a fee for a safer transaction. Across all respondents, the figure was 86%.

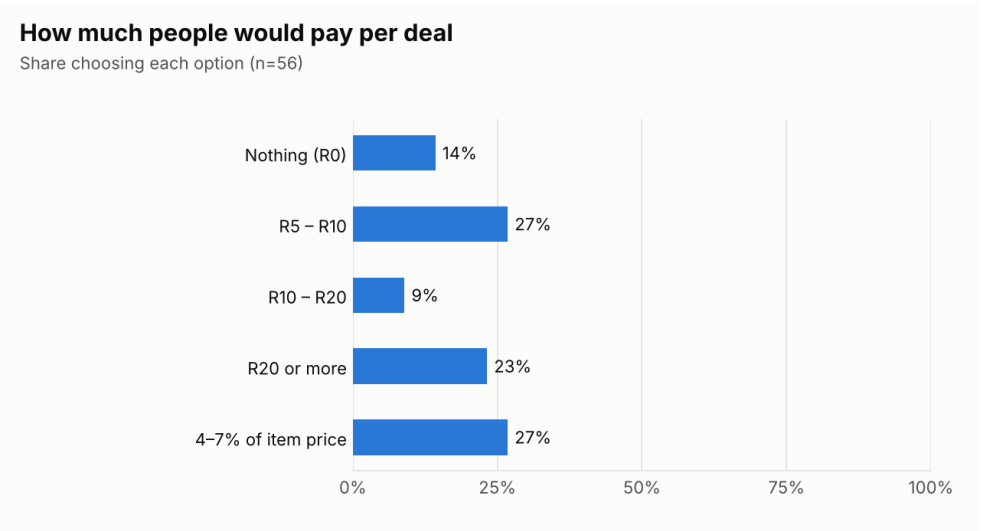


Figure 4: Fee preferences among all respondents answering this question ($n = 56$).

Among users answering the fee question, R5–R10 was the most common choice (36%), followed

by R20 or more (28%) and a percentage of the item price (20%). The most common choice was therefore a low fixed fee, although preferences were varied.

The reported payment-timing preferences were 54% after the deal, 26% before it, and 19% only for items above R1,000. These options mix two different questions: when to pay and which transactions should attract a fee. They should be separated in a future survey.

I have not established whether the selected fees would cover payment processing, safeguarding funds, support and disputes. The survey also asked about "guaranteed safety", which promises more than the proposed service has demonstrated.

Assessment: H2 has preliminary support as stated willingness to pay. Actual payment behaviour and a viable price remain untested.

4.5 Early-Access Sign-ups Provide a Limited Signal

Twenty-five of the 58 respondents (43%) left a phone number for early access. This is an observable action, but it was encouraged by an offer of a free first transaction. It also includes the full sample, rather than a confirmed count of Marketplace users.

I see this as interest in hearing more. It does not substitute for the planned "Pay Securely" test or show that someone would pay and complete a transaction through SafeTrade.

5 Evaluation Against Success Criteria

The original plan did not define a numerical threshold for "a meaningful portion". I used 50% for this evaluation. This was an assessment choice made after collection, rather than a threshold agreed before the survey; it should be read with that limitation.

Table 5: Evaluation against the original success criteria.

Criterion	Result for users	Assessment
A majority concerned about safety	58% felt unsafe	Met on the survey measure
A meaningful portion willing to pay	92% stated willingness	Met using the retrospective threshold
Interest in a simulated "Pay Securely" option	Test not run	Not measured

Feeling unsafe is used here as an indicator of safety concern; the two concepts are related but not identical. Meeting these survey measures does not establish that the underlying business assumptions hold.

Table 6: Status of the foundational assumptions.

Assumption	Status	Basis
H1: Value of safety	Preliminary support	Reported scam experiences and cancelled deals.
H2: Willingness to pay	Preliminary support	Stated willingness; no actual payment test.
H3: Trust in SafeTrade	Not directly tested	Feature preference does not establish provider trust.
H4: Workflow adoption	Not tested	No transaction or demand test completed.

6 Limitations of the Evidence

- **The solution was shown first.** The story may have increased concern and favourable responses. Without an unprimed comparison group, I cannot measure the size or direction of that effect reliably.
- **The target sample was small.** Only 26 respondents used Marketplace, and some question-level bases were smaller. Percentages can change noticeably with only a few responses.
- **Recruitment was narrow.** The sample was drawn through personal and student networks and was largely aged 18–24. It cannot represent South African Marketplace users as a whole.
- **Non-users were not screened out.** Some questions did not apply to them. Separating groups afterwards improves interpretation but does not fix the original questionnaire.
- **Commercial behaviour was not observed.** Sign-ups were recorded, but nobody was asked to pay or complete a SafeTrade transaction.
- **Some questions were poorly structured.** Fee bands overlapped and mixed amounts with percentages. Timing options mixed timing and transaction eligibility. The prototype promised "guaranteed safety" and used an opening scam statistic without a source.
- **Key assumptions remain open.** Trust in the provider, adoption during a real deal, operating costs and the legal route were not established.

7 Decision

7.1 Outcome Under the Framework

The evidence is mixed: two survey criteria were met, one was not measured, and trust and adoption remain open. I therefore classify the outcome as **Refine** under the original framework. This means the case needs more work before development can be justified.

7.2 Decision Taken

I am pausing SafeTrade. I will not build an MVP or start another validation phase at this stage. This is a decision about committing further time and resources with the evidence

available; it is not a finding that the idea cannot work.

7.3 Rationale

1. **The evidence is too limited to justify development.** The positive results come from a small target sample exposed to the proposed solution first. The behavioural criterion was never tested.
2. **I cannot yet show that the service would cover its costs.** R5–R10 was the most common fee selected, but there is no cost model to compare it with. Support and dispute handling would need to be included alongside payment costs.
3. **The central trust question remains unanswered.** SafeTrade would ask people who are already worried about fraud to trust a new company with their money. Preference for escrow does not resolve that concern.
4. **The route for handling funds has not been established.** Before any service receives real money, the applicable legal requirements, fund protections and dispute responsibilities would need to be established with qualified advisers and relevant payment partners. This study did not assess them.
5. **Further validation would be a separate commitment.** It would require a redesigned survey, more targeted recruitment and a behavioural test. I do not have enough evidence to commit to that phase now.

7.4 Conditions for Revisiting

The project remains available to reconsider. The following would strengthen the case for reopening it; none is a guarantee that development should proceed.

Table 7: Evidence needed before reconsidering development.

Condition	What it would help establish
An unprimed survey of at least 100 screened Marketplace users, with broader recruitment	Whether safety concerns persist beyond the current sample. This is a recruitment target, not a guarantee of representativeness.
A clearly described “Pay Securely” test with a real stated price and success thresholds defined in advance	Whether users take a meaningful next step at that price. The test should state that no live escrow service is being offered.
Direct testing of trust in an unfamiliar provider	Whether users accept the safeguards and information needed before they would entrust funds.
A cost model compared with credible payment evidence	Whether fees can cover payment, support, dispute and other operating costs.
An established legal and operational route for handling funds	Whether the proposed service can be delivered with appropriate protections.

8 What Was Retained and Learned

8.1 Retained Work

The survey prototype, anonymised dataset of 58 responses, data pipeline, original proposal and validation documentation have been retained. These provide a starting point if the project resumes. A revised survey or additional source may still require new mappings, schema changes and checks.

8.2 Lessons

- **Define the target respondent before collecting data.** More than half the sample fell outside the intended user group. Screening should have been part of the survey from the start.
- **Test the assumption that could stop the project.** I spent more effort establishing concern and price preference than testing whether people would trust the service and use it.
- **Protect personal information before it enters the workflow.** Removing it later does not undo exposure. Data handling needs to be designed alongside collection.
- **Check how results are produced.** The first notebook missed answers and misclassified fees. Systematic checks made those errors visible and improved the reliability of the analysis.
- **Separate explaining an idea from testing it.** The story helped people understand SafeTrade, but understanding the pitch and independently wanting the service are different things.
- **A decision to pause is still a useful result.** The purpose of validation was to make a better investment decision. I learned enough to see that building now would be premature.

9 Next Steps

No active work is planned. If I reopen the project, I would:

1. Redesign the questionnaire with screening, neutral wording, non-overlapping fee bands and direct trust questions. Ask problem questions before introducing SafeTrade, or use separate groups to test the effect of the story.
2. Recruit at least 100 Marketplace users through more varied channels and record relevant trading experience.
3. Define the demand-test action, target segment and success thresholds before running it. Present the proposed fee clearly and distinguish a concept test from a live service.
4. Establish operating costs and the legal route before collecting or holding transaction funds.
5. Reapply the decision framework, keeping stated interest separate from observed behaviour.

The next phase would need to answer whether users trust and adopt SafeTrade, and whether the service can be delivered sustainably. More positive survey responses alone would not settle those questions.

A Data Pipeline

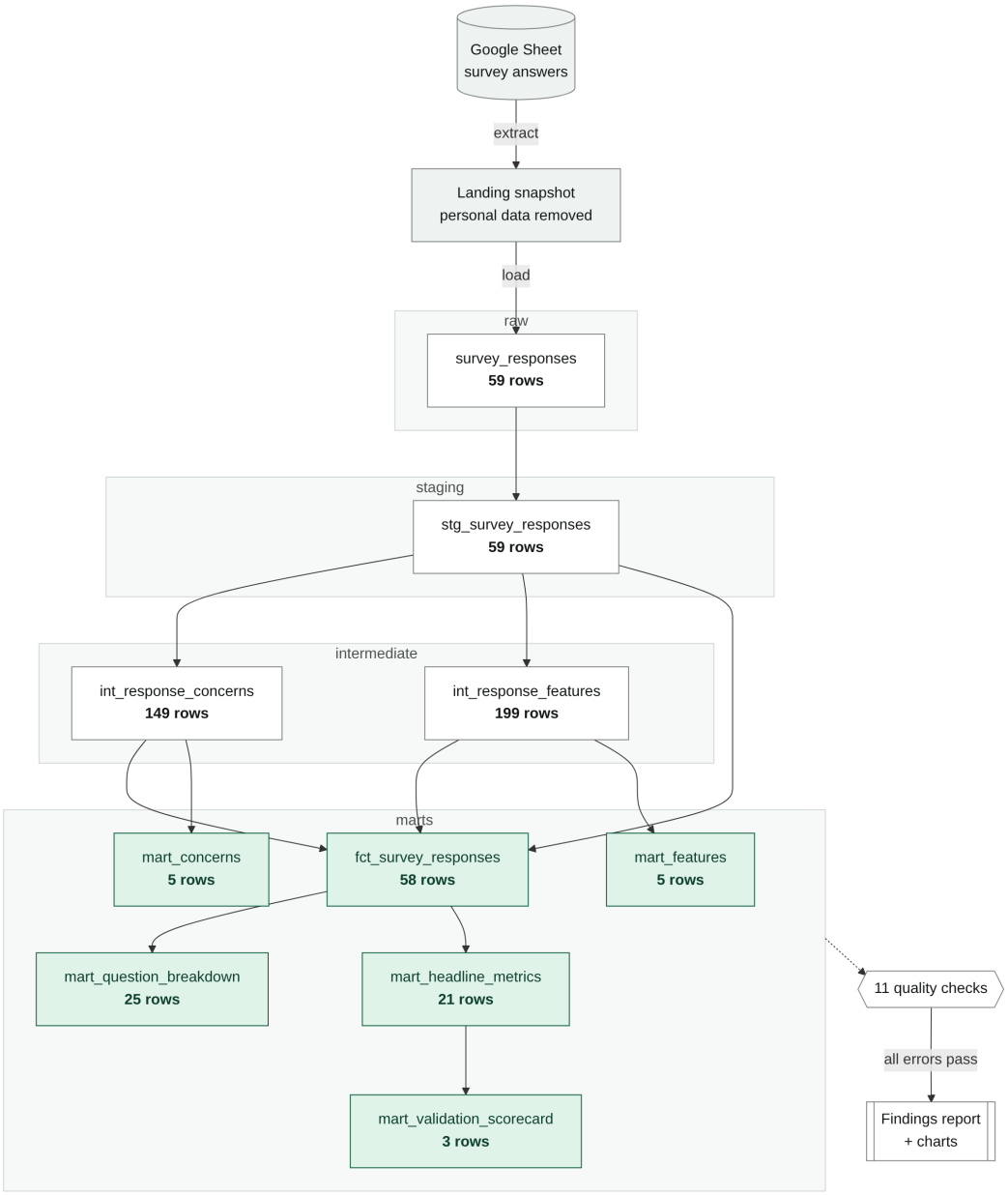


Figure 5: Original pipeline lineage diagram. The reported final run starts with 59 submissions and retains 58 after duplicate removal. Findings are published only after error-level quality checks pass.

Document preparation note. This revision preserves the numerical findings supplied in the original draft. The underlying dataset, pipeline, charts and April proposal were not independently checked during the editorial revision. Missing charts appear as labelled placeholders and can be restored by adding the original files under `figures/`. No chart values have been reconstructed.

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